CASE STUDY: THE "SHADOW ACCOUNT" TRAP (CYBERBULLYING)

What the Crime Is

Cyberbullying is the use of digital platforms such as social media, messaging apps, or gaming forums to harass, threaten, or humiliate another person. In this fictional scenario, the specific method used is identity impersonation and targeted harassment.

How It Typically Happens (Step-by-Step)

- Creation: An anonymous user creates a "shadow" or "confessions" account on a platform like Instagram, using a name similar to a college club.
- Baiting: The bully posts a cropped, out-of-context photo of a student, inviting others to "comment their thoughts" or "spill the tea".
- Escalation: As comments pour in, the bully sends direct, hateful messages to the victim from multiple fake accounts to create a sense of being surrounded.
- Isolation: The bully shares the victim's private academic struggles or personal photos, pressuring their friends to "unfollow" or "block" the victim.

Who Is Typically Targeted

College students who are socially active online or those who have recently experienced a public disagreement are often targets. Victims are usually chosen because they have a visible digital footprint that can be exploited.

The Consequences

For the victim, consequences include severe emotional distress, social withdrawal, and a decline in academic performance. For the bully, consequences under Indian law and college policy can include suspension, permanent expulsion, and legal action under the IT Act for digital harassment.

CASE STUDY: THE "BOIS LOCKER ROOM" INCIDENT

What the Crime Is

The "Bois Locker Room" incident was a high-profile case of **cyberbullying** and **online harassment** involving the unauthorized sharing of private photos and derogatory comments. It primarily centered on a private Instagram chat group where participants engaged in "doxxing" and the objectification of female students.

How It Typically Happens (Step-by-Step)

- **Creation:** Individuals form private, invitation-only groups on social media platforms like Instagram or WhatsApp.
- **Targeting:** Members share "screenshots" or photos of peers taken from their public profiles without consent.
- **Harassment:** The group is used to circulate lewd comments, "spill tea" (private gossip), or even threaten digital harm.
- **Exposure:** The private content is eventually leaked by a member or whistleblower, leading to massive public outcry and legal intervention.

Who Is Usually Targeted

The victims were primarily school and college-aged students. Studies show that **younger participants (aged 18-22)** and **females** are statistically more likely to be targets of such digital harassment.

The Consequences

For the victims, the incident led to extreme **psychological distress**, with many reporting severe levels of anxiety and depression. For the perpetrators, the case triggered investigations under the **IT Act** for identity theft and transmitting obscene material.

Source Reference

- **Case Name:** Bois Locker Room (2020)
- **Legal Context:** Handled under the Information Technology Act (Sections 66 and 67).
- **Prevention Resource:** National Cyber Crime Portal (**cybercrime.gov.in**) and Helpline **1930**.